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Longest species of Earthworm

Microchaetus rappi is an African giant earthworm, can reach a length of 6.7 meter (22 feet). *Drawida nilamburansis* is a south Indian (Kerala) species of earthworm and can reach a maximum length up to 1 meter (3 feet).

Nephridiopores are numerous and found throughout the body of the earthworm except a few anterior segments, through which the metabolic wastes are eliminated.

Anatomy

The body wall of the earthworm is very moist, thin, soft, skinny, elastic and consists of the cuticle, epidermis, muscles and coelomic epithelium. The epidermis consists of supporting cells, gland cells, basal cells and sensory cells. A spacious body cavity called the **coelom** is seen between the alimentary canal and the body wall. The coelom contains the coelomic fluid and serves as a **hydrostatic skeleton,** in which the coelomocytes are known to play a major role in regeneration, immunity and wound healing. The coelomic fluid of the earthworm is

Table 4.1: Morphological and anatomical differences between *Lampito mauritii* and *Metaphire posthuma*

S.No	Characters	*Lampito mauritii*	*Metaphire posthuma*
1.	**Shape and size**	Cylindrical 80 mm – 210 mm in length 3.5mm - 5.0 mm in width	Cylindrical 115 – 130 mm in length 5 mm in width
2.	**Colouration**	Light Brown	Dark Brown
3.	**Segmentation**	165 – 190 Segments	About 140 Segments
4.	**Clitellum**	14th – 17th Segments (4)	14th – 16th Segments (3)
5.	**Spermathecal opening**	Three pairs 6/7, 7/8 and 8/9	Four pairs 5/6, 6/7, 7/8 and 8/9
6.	**Pharynx**	3rd – 4th segment	Runs up to 4th Segment
7.	**Oesophagus**	5th segment	8th segment
8.	**Gizzard**	6th segment	8th – 9th segment
9.	**Intestine**	7th segment to anus	15th segment to anus
10.	**Intestinal caeca**	Absent	Present in 26th segment
11.	**Lateral hearts**	8 pairs from 6th to 13th segments	3 pairs from 7th to 9th segments
12.	**Pharyngeal nephridia**	5th - 9th segment	4th – 6th segment
13.	**Micronephridia**	14th to last segment	7th to last segment
14.	**Meganephridia**	19th to last segment	15th to last segment
15.	**Male genital pore**	18th segment	18th segment
16.	**Female genital pore**	14th segment	14th segment